

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 40

By Love

A RESOLUTION to honor Inez Gibbs Crutchfield of Nashville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Inez Gibbs Crutchfield; and

WHEREAS, Inez Crutchfield was a beloved Nashville social justice icon and educator who spent her life being a voice for the most vulnerable within her community and working for equal rights for all; and

WHEREAS, with a passion for civic engagement and an unwavering dedication to her quest for equality, Mrs. Crutchfield witnessed firsthand Civil Rights history in Nashville and claimed many firsts as an African-American woman; and

WHEREAS, born into a family of sharecroppers, Inez Crutchfield was raised in Watertown by her father, Dee Gibbs, a World War I veteran and businessman, and her mother, Bessie, an educator; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Crutchfield earned her bachelor's and master's degrees in health education from Tennessee A&I State College, now Tennessee State University; and

WHEREAS, she went on to serve as an assistant professor of health education at Tennessee State University and worked in the health and physical education department for nearly forty years; it was this position that brought her closer to the 1960 student sit-ins during the Civil Rights Movement; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Crutchfield was proud to offer students a solid support system during the sit-ins; she was known to transport her students to meetings to organize demonstrations, deliver food when students were arrested, and comfort students' parents; and

WHEREAS, a highly respected member of her community, Inez Crutchfield served as a member of a federal judicial selection committee and the board of the Bethlehem Center; she was also a member of the board at Meharry Medical College, where she helped guide the school's merger with Metro General Hospital; and

WHEREAS, Inez Crutchfield played a critical role in breaking race barriers, especially within the Davidson County Democratic Party Women's Club; she began as a member, and in 1975, she became the first African-American president of the Club; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Crutchfield went on to serve as Tennessee's first African-American woman representative on the Democratic National Committee and the first African American to hold an appointed and elected statewide position in the Tennessee State Federation of Democratic Women; and

WHEREAS, she remained active in politics even after her retirement, and in 2008, she served as a superdelegate supporting the then-future President Barack Obama; and

WHEREAS, although she generally opted to do her work behind the scenes, Inez Crutchfield was often credited with the political successes of several individuals; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to awards and accolades, Mrs. Crutchfield was the first African-American woman to receive the Athena Award in 1994, a most befitting honor that recognized her professional excellence; more recently, she received the Joe Kraft Humanitarian Award in 2019 in recognition of her commitment to community, home and hearth, and individuals in need; and

WHEREAS, Inez Crutchfield was deeply devoted to her family, and she always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Crutchfield enjoyed many years of marriage to the love of her life, Carl Crutchfield, and together, the couple were blessed with two cherished children, Carlton and Beth; and

WHEREAS, the epitome of perseverance and generosity, Inez Crutchfield was a wise and altruistic soul who impacted the lives of those who were blessed to know her, and she leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all her chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Crutchfield's quest for equality and her tireless efforts to bring about a more just, humane society will continue to inspire generations to come; and

WHEREAS, it is most fitting that we should pay tribute to her bountiful life of purpose and service; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Inez Gibbs Crutchfield, reflecting fondly upon her enduring legacy in Nashville and beyond.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.